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Phil of Animals – Morality of Zoos

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I loved zoos as a child, but I always pitied the tiger. Often, I ask myself whether this pity arose as a reaction to some degree of the tiger's sentience or as an internal manifestation of my natural empathetic capacity. While one is in response to real living being, the other is seemingly anthropomorphic insofar as it posits how tigers ought to be treated by contrasting it to how humans ought to be treated. to understand which is the origin of why I longed for the tiger to be 'free' in the wild requires a descriptive framework of what zoos are.

In examination, Dale Jamieson discusses the common notions of the motives of zoos: amusement, educational, research, conservationist, or preservationist. However, Jamieson refutes that each of these motives seem to accompany drastic challenges to providing a service which could otherwise be accomplished without the enclosure of nonhuman animals.¹ I argue that zoos represent a distinction between human life and that of life in nature.

The existence of zoos creates the distinction between human life as 'unnatural' and that of the wilderness as 'natural.' The 'natural' requires the privation of human influence.² A representation of an untouched ecosystem is enclosed for the life of an animal which inhabits that 'natural' ecosystem. Many of these enclosures together create a zoo. These enclosures represent the human interpretation of a proper environment for the subsequent animal. The distinction between humans as unnatural and nonhuman animals as natural is what drives the

¹ Dale Jamieson, *Against Zoos*, 1-5

² To draw on the common notion that human intervention in some natural fight between prey and predator is somehow 'unnatural'

common notion to question the existence of any degree of sentience. Therefore, the presence of Zoos is the illusion of a distinction between humans and the natural world.

An illusion which drives the notions of a distinction between beings in society as sentient (humans) while those outside it are beings existing in the natural order (animals). This is separable insofar as humans are sentient enough to do this. We both existed and lived in that same space though. The cost of the distinction between humans and animals has been the cost of the homes and lives of those animals. The distinction was in propertizing the natural world. Our guilt, or nostalgia, is what has led to the foundation which zoos rest upon.

Jamieson refutes that more often than not amusement is not the essence of the zoo experience.³ They are not in the same category as movie theaters or amusement parks, and even if one is to concede amusement is to some degree its purpose, that does not concede that zoos are morally okay. For example, how can a Tiger exist in a zoo and not be restricted. In 1900 Tigers roamed across Europe and Asia. Today they number in the mere thousands.⁴

Jamieson follows amusement by explaining the lack of reason education provides for the existence of zoos. He writes of a natural “indifference of the public to zoo’s educational efforts” and cites studies representing the lack of knowledge ‘zoo-goers’ experience viewing the animals.⁵ One is left to ask why education is present in zoos. Jamieson sites the numerous “pious platitudes” driving education, except posits them as unnecessary.⁶

The existence of zoos as educational catalysts for the public is commendable, though. For example, who is to deny that one individual will absorb and become interested in the ‘natural world’? How does that distinction come about? We, as the globally dominant species, are

³ Dale Jamieson, *Against Zoos*, pg 2

⁴ ~5000

⁵ Dale Jamieson, *Against Zoos*, pg 3

⁶ Dale Jamieson, *Against Zoos*, pg 2

separate from the natural order. Indirectly and directly, what have been the costs of this distinction manifesting to the extent that New York City can be referred to as ‘The Concrete Jungle?’

How this distinction came about is through our historical ingenuity as a species. I do not believe being the smartest species in the natural world distinguishes us as different from other species in nature. We, however, made boundaries. Society exists because of some imaginary social contract. Wherein as a collective all humans exist under a ‘just,’ ‘protected,’ ‘policed,’ system of law. This contract, imaginary as it is, cannot be reason enough to distinguish humans as any different from the animals in nature.

Humans may have separated themselves from nature by terraforming it into the suburbia of modern day, but nonetheless exist in the same space. The distinction is in that humans call this land property instead of the wild land it was. The transition from land of nature to property is the distinction which permeates between humans and nonhuman animals.

I believe zoos presuppose a distinction between humans as unnatural and the untouched world, remarkably little as it is, as ‘natural.’ It bothers me that the limited wild areas left represent a reason for the existence of their diminishment in the first place. For example, a zoo built in the 1950s would most likely have been for profit and entertainment. Only recently, when conservationism and preservationism have become a problem does education represent a viable reason for zoos.

Plato wrote that the vilest evil is the one disguised as the good. The argument that educating visitors to be interested into preserving what little wild areas are left is worth the cost-of-living beings in captivity seems counter intuitive. The goal is a normative existence with these

living beings in captivity. What that existence means is a relation of sustainability and equilibrium.

In the human manifestation of separation from nature, we as a species have created a problem. Humans believe our existence in a society separates us from the equilibrium of nature. However, nature is more balanced than society. For example, empires rise and fall because of systematic human greed which manifests a hierarchy deemed unsuitable for living by the masses. Even in the creation of zoos we distinguish our society as separate *and* powerful.

Powerful enough that we manifest the knowledge of the ‘natural world’ in representations of different species habitats. I mean to present that in creating zoos humans are merely demonstrating that we as a species are separate from nature. So much so that we can allocate land within society to be representative of that natural order we as a collective species left behind. However, I believe we did not leave it behind.

In original contract theories the idea of the natural world as separate from society permeates. I argue this separation is due to the interest in propertizing land instead of recognizing it as a finite ecosystem.

However, in our ignorance as a species we have destroyed much of the ecosystem which allowed us to become globally dominant. The land on which society is built out of and upon is that same land which resided a diverse ecosystem of species. We as the dominant species have conquered the globe, but this does not separate us from our place in its natural order.

Ben Minteer, in *Ecological Ethics in Captivity*, draws a distinction between animal rights and welfare. Minteer writes that the term ‘animal rights’ encompasses a view consequently “of

an animal's moral status" as one "entitled to fair treatment following ascriptions of moral personhood or inherent worth".⁷

Minteer defines animal welfare as the "consequentialist moral reasoning whereby the impacts of decisions and actions affecting the interest or good of the animal are weighed against other goods" including the good of humanity to decide what is morally correct.⁸ What both of these represent though are simply how animals ought to be treated and the pragmatic reality that there will be some compromise. However different, both represent the ascription of some moral importance to the welfare of animals.

Consequently, the existence of humans has relied heavily on animals and their relation to nature. When we were hunters and gathers, we existed in this natural order. Predators like the wolf still got to our sheep even though we domesticated dogs and built tools to fend them off. Soon we separated ourselves further with walls and borders. Then soon those borders represented some sense of duty to the collective within those borders. Over time we as humans have separated ourselves from nature by mirroring its ingenuity.

We cannot view ourselves as separate from nature because we have used nature to create that distinction. Furthermore, the act of building representations of the 'natural order' represents an acknowledgement of that separation. Zoos jailing animals, for conservationist, preservationist, educational, or entertainment purposes is a power relation of master and servant. The pragmatic welfare and normative goal zoos represent are no relevant in contrast to what they are. Zoos are the manifestation of the distinction between humans and nonhuman. One as

⁷ Ben Minteer, *Ecological Ethics in Captivity: Balancing Values and Responsibilities in Zoo and Aquarium Research under Rapid Global Change*, p 43

⁸ Ben Minteer, *Ecological Ethics in Captivity: Balancing Values and Responsibilities in Zoo and Aquarium Research under Rapid Global Change*, p 43

‘unnatural’ and the other ‘natural’ merely because of its existence not within an imaginary social contract.

Zoos are in nature unethical as they are routed in a misled distinction defining human existence outside the natural order. We are animals as much as any. Our existence in society has been at the cost of other species. Only as moral beliefs start to evolve does the hierarchical nature of zoos and their treatment of animals as beings outside the human realm become noticeable. Abolishing zoos might not be the answer but keeping them only leaves a symbolic distinction between humanity and beasts. I do pity that tiger I saw. And I firmly believe I pity their existence as it was my species who has limited them to such a life wherein more tigers exist in captivity than in the wild.